Republicans' lame duck priorities won't fly

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Minnesota still a potential spoiler for Democrats
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Democrats’ investigations will target individual trade deals

Republicans' lame duck priorities won't fly. Republicans’ governing trifecta is likely set to wind down beginning this November (Democrats have 90% odds in the House, 60% in the Senate). With limited legislative days left in the year, pending impeachment proceedings and crucial funding bills may cause this year’s lame duck session to produce less legislation than we’ve previously assessed.

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The structural dynamics in Congress cast a gloomy picture for the GOP: there are only 24 legislative days left this year and all 12 full-year appropriations bills have yet to pass. Looking ahead to the midterms, GOP members have expressed concern that attendance in both chambers will dip after a rousing defeat, further complicating vote counts in an unusually condensed – and consequential – legislative period.
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Taken together, these factors suggest the legislative agenda after the midterms won’t be packed; a short-term punt on government funding, past the 11 December deadline, is likely. The Senate’s permitting bill does remain likely to pass both chambers, but with downside risks from the compressed timeline and Democrats’ lingering questions about White House commitments on permitting freezes.
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Key national security bills are still in limbo. The National Defense Authorization Act (NDAA) has yet to be finalized into a “conferenced” text between the House and Senate Armed Services Committees; the Trump administration’s requested reconciliation bills have lost steam and are now having to narrow in scope and topline; and the vital intelligence authorization bill is on the rocks due to its politically contentious provisions on surveillance powers. Dealing with limited procedural runway, these bills may be packaged together to maximize their chance of passage. Reconciliation, on the other hand, will likely be downsized to a package around $80-$150 billion to maximize its political chances but will face long

odds all the same.

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Internal political jockeying will also define the lame duck period, especially if Democrats take both chambers and shift their focus toward the 120th Congress. Factional infighting over future GOP leadership in Congress could limit the extent of policy action, especially if House Speaker Mike Johnson (R-LA) decides to run for minority leader, a move that would anger some in the conference.

Minnesota still a potential spoiler for Democrats. The trend wherein Democratic Senate candidates in Democratic-held seats poll considerably worse than they should be, given the left-ward shift in the national environment, has continued this week, setting up Minnesota in particular as a potential spoiler race for Democrats.

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What was a sparsely-polled race has seen a number of new polls in the last two weeks, but that hasn't boosted the polling standing of the Democratic candidate, Lieutenant Governor Peggy Flanagan. She still holds only a small lead over her Republican opponent, not exceeding five points in any poll so far.

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This small lead, essentially unchanged from the margin by which Democrats won the state in 2024, is probably the result of idiosyncratic local conditions in Minnesota, in particular Flanagan's ties to the relatively unpopular Governor Tim Walz. Anti-incumbent voting can cut both ways, and where Democrats are statewide incumbents, it may work against them, tempering their gains from 2024. Flanagan's weakness shouldn't be read as an indication that polls elsewhere are substantially overstating Democratic strength.

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Flanagan is ultimately likely to win the race, though not by much, and her apparent weakness could incentivize Republicans to push harder on the Minnesota race in the closing weeks of the campaign—especially if they come to see it as a more plausible win than Ohio or Texas. A Democratic loss in Minnesota would make it much harder to flip the chamber.

Democrats' investigations will target Trump's trade deals. As the midterms approach, committee leadership in the House and Senate is coordinating an investigatory push into President Donald Trump's trade policies; this will be a focus for Democrats in 2027.

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Democrats are likely to target individual business deals, rather than entire tariff regimes, in their planned slate of congressional investigations. This won't change tariff policy: While Democrats intend to hold votes to roll back some tariffs, the President's veto power makes any serious curb on current tariffs all but impossible without significant Republican defections. Instead, committees will focus on specific companies and entities that have benefitted from trade deals with the current administration.

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Lead committees in the House have previously coordinated their plans to investigate issues within Trump's DOJ and the Jeffrey Epstein probe (see: Democrats need a bluer national environment to flip South Carolina, 28 September 2026). Trump's reduction of tariffs on Switzerland and easing of export controls on the UAE are now rising on the Democrats' agenda, driven by these deals' appearance of quid pro quo.

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Candidates on the campaign trail have elevated the Democratic party's focus on anti-corruption efforts as a central pillar of their platform. Tying the administration's broadly unpopular trade policy to that

corruption narrative is likely to be a winning move for Democrats, in the midterms and beyond.

Quote of the Day

“We have asked Ambassador Guilfoyle to resign.” - Incoming White House Press Secretary Katie Zacharia in her first press conference this morning. A series of stories about US Ambassador to Greece Kimberly Guilfoyle have detailed how she promised political access in return for money and personal favors; she resigned shortly after this press conference.

On the Radar

12-18 October: IMF and World Bank Annual Meetings

30-31 October: G20 Foreign Ministers' meeting

3 November: National midterm elections

9 November: Congress returns from recess

18-19 November: APEC leaders meeting in China

11 December: Government funding runs out

14-15 December: G20 summit in Florida

10 January: US-China tariff truce expires

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